

Ed Catmull

Creativity, Inc. & Sustaining a Creative Culture

b. 1945 · Co-founder & former President, Pixar & Walt Disney Animation



"If you give a good idea to a mediocre team, they will screw it up."

"Failure isn't a necessary evil. It isn't evil at all."

1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

Catmull ran the most consistently creative studio in film history. His lesson for managers: protecting the fragile early idea, and building candid feedback mechanisms, matters more than any individual genius. This is team creativity made operational at scale.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

American computer scientist and co-founder of Pixar, later president of Pixar and Disney Animation. A pioneer of computer graphics (the Catmull–Clark subdivision surface), he spent his management career studying how to keep a large organisation reliably creative.

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
The Braintrust	Candid, no-authority peer feedback on works in progress
Protect the fragile idea	Early ideas are 'ugly babies' needing shelter
Candour over politeness	Systems that make honesty safe and routine
Failure as R&D	Treat mistakes as the cost of doing something new
Manage the unseen	Surface the hidden forces that undermine creativity

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Create candid peer-review forums with no decision authority
- Shelter early-stage ideas from premature judgement
- Separate feedback from hierarchy so truth can travel upward
- Normalise failure as inseparable from originality
- Continuously hunt for the invisible barriers to candour

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Lessons drawn from one exceptional creative company
- Braintrust depends on rare, high-trust culture
- Hard to transplant to non-creative or low-trust settings
- Narrative, practitioner evidence rather than controlled study
- Founder-era conditions may not generalise

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- *Creativity, Inc.* a defining text on creative leadership
- Braintrust widely emulated as a feedback model
- Turing Award (2019) for computer-graphics foundations
- Bridged technical and creative management thinking
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Unit 2 creative culture

SELECTED WORKS

CREATIVITY, INC. <i>Overcoming the Unseen Forces</i> CATMULL · 2014	CREATIVITY, INC. (EXPANDED) <i>with Amy Wallace</i> CATMULL · 2023	SUBDIVISION SURFACES <i>Catmull–Clark (technical)</i> CATMULL · 1978	THE PIXAR TOUCH (contrib.) <i>History of Pixar</i> PRICE · 2008
--	---	---	--

REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

- Catmull, E. and Wallace, A. (2014) *Creativity, Inc.* New York: Random House.
- Catmull, E. (2008) 'How Pixar Fosters Collective Creativity', *Harvard Business Review*, 86(9), pp. 64–72.